

WHAT IS ECOTOURISM?

Definition, principles, pros, cons and real-world examples • LEVEL B



Ecotourism takes visitors to natural areas with a focus on conservation, education, and supporting local communities.

Ecotourism is about more than simply visiting natural attractions — it is about doing so in a responsible and sustainable manner. The term refers to travelling to natural areas with a clear focus on environmental conservation, while educating tourists about the importance of protecting the places they visit. Unlike conventional mass tourism, ecotourism is designed to minimise its negative impact on the environment and to generate direct benefits for local communities.

The global **ecotourism** market generated \$92.2 billion in 2019 and is forecast to reach \$103.8 billion by 2027. It has benefited destinations such as Madagascar, Ecuador, Kenya, and Costa Rica, helping to provide economic growth in some of the world's most **impoverished communities**. But like all forms of tourism, ecotourism has its drawbacks too — and distinguishing genuine ecotourism from ordinary tourism with a green label is not always straightforward.

The Three Core Principles of Ecotourism

Sustainable ecotourism is guided by three interconnected principles: **conservation**, community, and education. Each plays an essential role in ensuring that tourism genuinely benefits the places it visits, rather than simply exploiting them.

■ CONSERVATION

■ COMMUNITY

■ EDUCATION

Protecting **biodiversity** and natural ecosystems through **sustainable** tourism income.

Empowering local communities, creating jobs, and reducing poverty and dependence on **poaching**.

Increasing environmental awareness and creating future conservationists through direct nature experience.

One of the most **overlooked** aspects of **ecotourism** is its educational component. Increasing awareness about environmental issues and promoting a deeper appreciation for nature is arguably just as important as **conservation** itself. Ecotourism also educates children about nature, potentially creating new generations of conservationists. Even adult visitors may learn new ways to reduce their **ecological footprints**.

The Benefits: Community, Conservation and Economic Growth

When managed sustainably, **ecotourism** can support poverty **alleviation** by providing employment for local communities and offering them an alternative **livelihood** outside of unsustainable practices such as **poaching**. A study published in the Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences found that communities near **conservation** areas in Costa Rica had poverty rates 16% lower than those in areas without protected parks.

Ecotourism also gives natural areas economic value — and that value helps raise funds to protect them. When tour providers in destinations such as the Galapagos Islands are required to conserve water and energy, recycle waste, and hire local employees with fair wages, the entire local ecosystem benefits. Countries such as Costa Rica have seen their forest cover grow from 26% in 1983 to over 52% in 2021, in large part due to policies that promote ecotourism and protect natural areas.

"Only if we understand, will we care. Only if we care, will we help. Only if we help, shall all be saved."

— Jane Goodall, conservationist

\$92B

global ecotourism market in 2019

90%

of tourists visiting Tanzania seek ecotourism activities

16%

lower poverty near conservation areas in Costa Rica

52%

of Costa Rica now forest — up from 26% in 1983

The Risks: Greenwashing and Unintended Harm

As **ecotourism** has grown into a major industry, so has the risk of **greenwashing** — where businesses present themselves as environmentally responsible without genuinely providing substantial benefits to the environment or local communities. For travellers, this means that researching tour operators carefully before booking is essential. The International Union for **Conservation** of Nature (IUCN) cautions that some areas are simply not appropriate for ecotourism development, and that not every business model will be **viable** in the wider tourism market.

Even genuinely well-intentioned **ecotourism** can cause harm. When humans **interact** with animals or natural environments, there is always a risk of unintended consequences. One study found that ecotourism can alter animal behaviours in ways that make them more vulnerable to predators or poachers. When ecotourism activities become too popular, they can lead to new infrastructure construction, increased pressure on local resources, pollution, and erosion. In some cases, the expansion of tourist operations has displaced **indigenous** communities from their traditional lands — preventing them from benefiting from the very economic opportunities that ecotourism was supposed to create.

ACTIVITIES

1 Read the article and decide if these statements are True (T), False (F), or Not Given (NG).

- 1 Ecotourism focuses on conservation but does not involve education.
- 2 Communities near conservation areas in Costa Rica had lower poverty rates.
- 3 Costa Rica's forest cover has more than doubled since 1983.
- 4 All businesses that market themselves as ecotourism genuinely protect the environment.
- 5 Ecotourism always has a positive impact on local animal behaviour.
- 6 Jane Goodall is described as a well-known conservationist.

2 Match the highlighted words and phrases in the article to their meanings.

- 1 done in a way that can continue long-term without causing lasting damage
- 2 the process of making misleading environmental claims to attract customers
- 3 a way of earning money and supporting oneself and one's family
- 4 illegal hunting of animals, often of protected species
- 5 the variety of plant and animal life in a particular environment
- 6 a place set aside to protect animals and the environment

3 Read the article again and answer these questions in full sentences.

- 1 How does ecotourism differ from conventional mass tourism?
- 2 How did ecotourism help reduce poverty in Costa Rica?
- 3 What is 'greenwashing' and why is it a problem for travellers?
- 4 In what ways can even well-intentioned ecotourism cause harm?
- 5 What practical steps can travellers take to ensure their ecotourism is genuine?

4 Discussion: Jane Goodall says 'Only if we understand, will we care.' Write a paragraph (80–100 words) explaining whether you agree — and how ecotourism supports or contradicts this idea.

Use evidence from the article.

Consider: Can tourism genuinely change people's relationship with nature?

■ TALKING POINTS

Would you choose an ecotourism holiday over a traditional beach resort? Why / Why not?

How can you tell the difference between genuine ecotourism and greenwashing?

Should governments set strict limits on tourist numbers in ecologically sensitive areas?

Can tourism ever truly be sustainable — or does visiting a place always damage it?

